



Climate change

Records show that the world is getting warmer, and this change in climate may threaten marine habitats and coastal cities. Global warming could melt the polar ice and raise sea levels, and this would result in some islands disappearing underwater. Warmer oceans could increase the frequency and strength of hurricanes and other storms, as well as cause damage to coral reefs. The rising level of carbon dioxide in the air, which is the main cause of global warming, is also increasing the acidity of the oceans, and this could be catastrophic for a lot of marine life.

MELTING ICE

The polar ice sheets in Antarctica and Greenland are melting, and the sea ice at the North Pole is getting thinner. In September 2012—the end of the northern summer—the area of the Arctic Ocean covered by ice was the smallest on record. The dwindling ice cover could have a big impact on Arctic wildlife, especially on polar bears that hunt on the pack ice.



▲ FLOODED STREET

Many cities in Bangladesh already suffer flooding due to heavy monsoon rain, as here in Dhaka, the capital. But rising sea levels could make some cities uninhabitable.

RISING SEA LEVELS

As continental ice sheets melt, meltwater flowing off the land makes global sea levels rise. It is likely that they will rise by at least 3 ft (1 m) over the next century. This three-foot rise would flood 17 percent of Bangladesh. It would also expose coastal cities such as New York, London, and Shanghai to the risk of serious flooding. What's more, several low-lying island nations could vanish completely.

